

did come close. The Brother, though, edged ahead to claim victory by virtue of better quality.

In terms of the B&W copying quality, the Lexmark 7710 and the HP 5510 tied for the top spot, with the HP PSC 2310 and the Brother 3240 tying for second place.

In case, you are required to do a lot of copying—whether text or colour—a smart choice would be to go in for the Lexmark X7170. Although you may have to do a minor compromise in terms of speed, the X7170 provides you with really good printouts, which are sure to come in handy during presentations or meetings.

OCR

The last test we conducted was the OCR (Optical Character Recognition) test. We scanned a newspaper article using Abbyy Reader 7 Professional, and let the software read the characters without any tweaks and at all the default settings. We were checking for errors given by the software. The HP 2310 and the Epson CX1500 gave us zero errors! They even read the characters embedded in an image (a logo). The worst was the Brother MFC210c, with 10 errors!

The only problem Lexmark X7170 gave us was that it did not read the image file too clearly but, the text part of the document was completely error-free.

All said and done, and as the smell of ink and the reams of papers were cleared up, the Lexmark X7170 came out the clear winner on account of its competitive pricing, extensive feature set and miserly usage of ink during printing. Yes, it was not the top in all segments but if you look at the whole picture, it fared consistently better than

the others when taken as a package. So, let's hear it for the Lexmark X7170, the Best Buy Gold winner!

The Best Buy Silver award goes to HP PSC 2310. Though cheaper than Lexmark X7170, it lost due to its running costs. Cartridges are costlier by almost Rs 500 than the Lexmark ones and print around seven pages less with 10 per cent ink.



Lexmark X7170

Photo MFDS

Only three MFDS qualified for this segment—the Lexmark P6250, the Epson RX630 and the HP PhotoSmart 2608.

Features

All the above mentioned MFDS came with MMC Readers and were PictBridge compliant. They also had some of the sleekest LCD screens we have seen, some of the top cell phone screens included!

The build quality of all of these printers was excellent and really sturdy; the Epson RX630 even came with a transportation lock for the scanner element. None of the other systems had this feature.

Performance Printing

In our Printer tests, the test process was the same as that for Inkjet Printers. The fastest one here was the HP PhotoSmart 2608, which printed our test document in 11 seconds, while the Epson RX 630 and Lexmark P6250 were distant runners-up with 31 and 56 seconds respectively. So, if you want fast printouts from your

MFD, the HP PhotoSmart 2608 is the one to go for—it will save you tons of time to get on with your business or whatever else you want to have time for!

The same story was repeated in our combi-doc and photo printing tests. The HP PhotoSmart 2608 took 31.3 and 263.8 seconds respectively, as compared to 39 and 473.81 seconds for the Epson RX 630 printer and 145 and 312 seconds for Lexmark P6250.

The great thing about this HP printer is that it's not only devastatingly fast, but also does a stellar job of printing in terms of quality. The text printouts were crisp and sharp. Eventually, though, in terms of pure quality of the picture, the HP was pipped to the post—by a marginal difference—by the Epson.

Since these are classified as photo MFDS, the bulk of the emphasis is on photo printouts, with speed and quality both being important. As always, though, quality is preferred over speed.

In terms of printing speed, the HP PhotoSmart 2608 was blazing fast, with a text document printing time of 11 seconds, as compared to 31 and 56 for the Epson and Lexmark.



HP PSC 2310 all-in-one



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